

Comment on Election Audit Standards issued by the U.S. Election Assistance Commission on February 23, 2026.

- **From William J. Kresse***

I applaud the U.S. Election Assistance Commission (“Commission”) in issuing the proposed “Election Audit Standards.” These Standards are thorough and show that much thought was put into creating these.

I am particularly pleased to see that all of these matters are addressed as “Topics”:

- Objective
- Professional
- Effective
- Secure
- Accountable

And that within these Topics, the matters of Ethics, Impartiality, Independence, Competence, and Transparency are discussed. These matters are particularly vital if election audits are to promote confidence in our elections.

If I may, I would like to suggest that in the near future the Commission consider the credentialing of those conducting or at least overseeing election audits. While such qualities as Transparency are important in gaining confidence, public confidence relies not just on “how” an election audit is conducted, but also on “who” is conducting it.

Credentialing election auditors would ensure the public that those conducting or overseeing election audits are competent in performing the task. The public would be assured that based on a combination of education, training, background, and testing, election audits are in the hands of people that the Commission has deemed to be competent for the undertaking.

Additionally, credentialing election auditors will create a mechanism for holding election auditors accountable for any violations of professional standards. As with any other credentialed profession, the credentialing body would be able to discipline those found to have willfully violated the professional standards.

Going forward, I would suggest that public confidence in our elections can be enhanced through professional election audits. However, for the public to perceive these election audits to be professional, they must be conducted by a cadre of professional election auditors. In order to demonstrate to the public that election audits are being conducted by

professionals, the Commission should begin the task of setting in place the standards and the mechanisms to credential professional election auditors.

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